

Resource: Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

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Making Sense of the Exile

The kings and people of Israel repeatedly disobeyed God and failed to keep their special agreement (the covenant) with him. As a result, God announced that he would bring the covenant curses upon them (see [Deuteronomy 28:15-68](#); compare [Jeremiah 4:13](#); [Amos 5:11](#); [Micah 6:14-15](#)). God sent the Assyrian and Babylonian armies to carry out this punishment, and many Israelites went into exile (see [2 Kings 24:1-25:21](#)). They were forced to leave their land.

The exile of Israel influenced many psalms, impacting their images and themes.

In [Psalm 89](#), the psalmist expresses the sadness, pain, and confusion the Israelites experienced when they were living in exile through questions:

- Has God abandoned David's royal family line ([89:38-39](#))?
- How long will God's anger last ([Psalm 89:46](#))?
- Does God understand human weakness ([89:47-48](#))?
- Is God true to his nature ([89:49](#))?
- Is God fair by not avenging his people ([89:50-51](#))?

During and after the exile, God's people had many questions. Some doubted God's ability to rule. Instead of ignoring these doubts, wise readers listen, think about, and study the answers in Scripture.

The final answer came through the Lord Jesus Christ (see [Isaiah 52-54](#); [Luke 1:46-55](#), [67-79](#); [4:18-19](#); [Romans 6:6](#), [16-23](#); [Hebrews 12:22-24](#)). Yet, those who lived during the exile could only partly imagine a hopeful future. They asked difficult questions and lived without clear answers.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 26:27-45](#); [Deuteronomy 28:36-37](#), [63-68](#); [30:1-5](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [24:1-25:21](#); [Ezra 5:12](#); [Psalms 89](#); [107](#); [126](#); [Isaiah 5:13](#); [27:13](#); [52:1-12](#); [59:10](#); [Jeremiah 2:37](#); [3:18](#); [4:13](#); [Ezekiel 6:9](#); [20:41](#); [37:1-14](#); [Amos 5:11](#); [Micah 6:14-15](#)

Marriage and Sexuality

Scripture considers marriage holy from the very beginning. Sexual expression is an important part of it ([Genesis 2:23-25](#)). The first human sin caused a disruption in all relationships. This first happened between God and humans, then between husband and wife, and even between humans and creation ([Genesis 3](#)). The division between Adam and Eve showed in their sexuality. They could no longer be naked in the garden without feeling shame.

In Proverbs, the wise teacher often warns young men to avoid sexual temptations outside of marriage ([Proverbs 2:16-22](#); [5:1-23](#); [6:20-7:27](#)). While a young man might find other women attractive, acting on these temptations can have severe consequences. His family and career goals might become destroyed. Proverbs advises young men to build a strong relationship with their wives. The Scripture encourages men to have a healthy marital relationship instead of being with other women ([5:15-20](#)).

Although this section of Proverbs was first written to teach young men, everyone can think about these issues of marriage and sexuality. The book of Proverbs encourages everyone to recognize the holiness and beauty of marital love as God, the wise Creator, planned it.

The New Testament emphasizes the holiness of sexuality and its proper expression within marriage. Jesus refers to the creation story in Genesis to emphasize the intended permanence of marriage. After quoting [Genesis 2:24](#), he says, "So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate" ([Matthew 19:3-6](#)). The apostle Paul talks

about the importance of maintaining sexual intimacy in marriage to prevent temptation by Satan ([1 Corinthians 7:3-5](#)). God wants those who marry to stay faithful to each other and avoid harmful sexual activities that could damage their holy relationship (see [Hebrews 13:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:18-25](#); [Proverbs 2:16-22](#); [5:15-20](#); [6:20-35](#); [7:1-27](#); [Jeremiah 5:7-11](#); [Hosea 2:20](#); [Malachi 2:14-16](#); [Matthew 19:4-6](#); [22:30](#); [1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#); [Hebrews 13:4](#)

Material Reward

Some people in the Old Testament period believed that righteous people would usually prosper in material ways. They treated the wisdom sayings found in books like Proverbs as general rules for life. Other biblical books, such as Job and Ecclesiastes, challenge this view. When this belief is treated as a guarantee, it can lead to false guilt or blame when prosperity does not come, and to spiritual complacency when it does.

The suffering of Job serves as an example. His friends accepted a traditional theological view that said Job's troubles were evidence against him ([19:5](#)). They claimed his suffering was punishment for his sin ([4:7-9](#)). They believed Job's penalty was probably less than he deserved ([11:6](#)). Yet, God's analysis of Job's life proved this idea false ([42:7-8](#)). God testified to his special relationship with Job and restored Job's good reputation as his servant.

Material well-being does not always conflict with spiritual blessings. Yet, when we see blessings as material gain, "the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth, and the desire for other things" often distract us from spiritual blessings ([Mark 4:19](#); see also [Luke 6:25](#)). We can easily become greedy, envious, and lustful. Our self-worth might depend on what we own, even if we still owe money on it. This perspective is not Christian but reflects a worldly way of thinking ([1 John 2:15-17](#)).

In his suffering, Job went from complaining to showing humility. He recognized God's righteous power ([Job 40:4-5](#); [42:2-6](#)). We can also regard difficulties as chances for spiritual growth ([James 1:2-4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 13:2](#); [1 Kings 10:23](#); [Job 4:7-9](#); [11:6](#); [19:5](#); [Psalms 49:16-20](#); [73:1-28](#); [Proverbs 14:20](#); [18:11](#);

[28:11](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:10-20](#); [Jeremiah 17:11](#); [Zephaniah 1:18](#); [Matthew 27:57](#); [Mark 4:19](#); [10:17-25](#); [Luke 6:24-25](#); [16:10-31](#); [1 Timothy 6:17](#); [James 1:2-4](#), [9](#); [5:1](#); [1 John 2:16](#); [3 John 1:2](#)

Messages Against the Nations

Why did Israel's prophets speak to nations who were unlikely to hear their messages? Why did the prophets care about these nations' thoughts and actions?

The real audience was God's people. These messages reminded them that God does not have a double standard. He judges the sins of his people and those of other nations. Judgment begins "with the family of God" ([1 Peter 4:17](#)).

But it does not stop there. God will judge everyone, both inside and outside Israel, who rebels against him. Everyone must recognize the Lord as the one true and sovereign God.

The people of Judah often trusted nations like Egypt to save them from foreign enemies. They did not realize that God used other nations to judge them. The prophets reminded the people that no nation on earth can replace God. In the end, all nations will bow before him in worship.

The messages against foreign nations reminded the covenant community that even though God judged them for their sins, they remained his precious people. The main accusation against these foreign nations was that they persecuted and insulted God's chosen people. This offended God. The negative part of God's covenant with Abraham was still active. God says he will "curse those who curse you" ([Genesis 12:3](#)).

God's main goal in history is to bring glory to himself. By exiling his sinful people and judging their arrogant oppressors, God showed his power and holiness. Despite the exile to Babylon, there was still hope for the positive side of the covenant to be fulfilled: "all the families of the earth will be blessed through you" ([Genesis 12:3](#); see also [Romans 11:1-27](#)). God had not finished the plans for his people. He would ultimately glorify himself by returning them from the distant lands where he had scattered them.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:3](#); [Deuteronomy 23:3-6](#); [Isaiah 13:1-23:18](#); [Jeremiah 25:29](#); [46:1-51:64](#); [Ezekiel 9:6](#); [25:1-32:32](#); [36:23](#); [39:7](#); [Daniel 4:17](#); [Amos 1:1-](#)

[2:3](#); [3:2](#); [Obadiah 1:1-16](#); [John 15:18-24](#); [Acts 3:25-26](#); [Romans 2:9-10](#); [11:1-27](#); [Ephesians 1:3-14](#); [1 Peter 4:17](#); [Revelation 18:1-24](#)

Miracles

Miracles often happened in the Bible. They were especially common during the time of Moses and the ministries of Elijah, Elisha, Jesus, and his apostles. The Bible does not try to prove miracles. It just reports them. Miracles show God's power over creation and his compassion for human needs.

Miracles can lead people to believe in God ([John 2:23](#)). But true belief requires more than just witnessing a miracle (see [John 12:37](#)). Miracles remind us that anything is possible for God ([Mark 9:21-23](#); compare [Matthew 19:26](#); [Mark 10:27](#); [Luke 1:37](#); [18:27](#)).

Jesus performed many miracles during his ministry, including healing the sick, casting out demons, controlling nature, and resurrecting the dead. He showed deep love for people by meeting their needs. Many followed him because of these miracles ([John 6:2](#)). Yet, he warned against following him only for the miracles ([John 6:26](#)).

The three greatest miracles related to Jesus are:

1. His arrival as "the Word" of God in human flesh ([John 1:14](#)).
2. His resurrection from the dead ([Matthews 28](#); [Mark 16:1-8](#); [Luke 24:1-53](#); [John 20:1-31](#); [Acts 1:3](#); [1 Corinthians 15:3-8](#); see also [Acts 23:6](#); [26:8](#)).
3. The miracle of spiritual rebirth ([John 3:3-8](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [Ephesians 2:8-10](#)).

Jesus came into the world to save it and to die for sins, showing God's great love for humanity ([John 3:16](#); [Romans 5:8](#); [8:32](#); [Ephesians 2:4-5](#); [1 John 3:1-2](#)). God resurrecting Jesus from the dead shows his power over death and gives us hope for eternal life ([1 Peter 1:3-9](#)). Anyone who trusts in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord is reborn as a child of God and receives eternal life ([John 1:12](#); [3:36](#); [Romans 5:1-2](#); [1 John 5:11-13](#)).

The miraculous work of Jesus continued through his followers, as shown in the book of Acts (for example, [Acts 3:1-11](#); [5:12-15](#); [6:8](#); [8:6-7](#); [9:32-42](#); [14:3](#)). Filled with the Holy Spirit, the apostles

and other Christian leaders performed these miracles to show the power and truth of the Christian message ([14:3](#); see [John 3:2](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 19:23-26](#); [28:1-20](#); [Mark 10:23-27](#); [Luke 1:30-38](#); [18:24-27](#); [24:1-53](#); [John 1:12-14](#); [3:2-8](#); [16](#); [20:1-21:25](#); [Acts 4:29-31](#); [5:12-16](#); [6:8](#); [8:4-23](#); [9:32-42](#); [14:3-4](#); [26:8](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [8](#); [8:32](#); [Ephesians 2:4-5](#); [8-10](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#); [1 Peter 1:3-5](#); [1 John 5:12-13](#)

Miraculous Signs in the Gospel of John

The Gospels use three words to describe Jesus' miraculous works. In Matthew, Mark, and Luke, the Greek word *dunamis* means "power." It describes an act of raw force that amazes people and makes them realize that God is working through Jesus (see [Mark 6:2](#)).

The apostle John does not use the popular term *dunamis* for Jesus' miracles. Instead, he calls each miracle a "sign" (Greek *sēmeion*). This means an event with deeper significance. John also refers to Jesus' miracles as "works" (Greek *erga*, see [John 10:38](#); [7:3](#); [9:3](#)). Jesus' miracles were part of the work God gave him to do to show the Father to the world ([17:4](#)).

John's Gospel records seven miraculous signs during Jesus' ministry:

1. Jesus changed water into wine ([John 2:1-11](#)).
2. Jesus healed an official's son ([4:46-54](#)).
3. Jesus healed a paralyzed man ([5:1-17](#)).
4. Jesus fed five thousand people ([6:1-15](#)).
5. Jesus walked on water ([6:16-21](#)).
6. Jesus healed a blind man ([9:1-41](#)).
7. Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead ([11:1-44](#)).

John also notes a miraculous catch of fish after Jesus' resurrection ([John 21:4-14](#)). Most of these signs led people to trust in Christ ([2:11](#); [4:53](#); [11:45-48](#)).

Yet, Jesus' goals went beyond the signs. The miraculous signs were like road markers. They pointed to a greater truth. A miraculous sign often comes with a talk from Jesus, explaining the truth it reveals.

For example, Jesus fed the five thousand men, not just to meet their physical needs. But he showed that he is "the bread of life." He would give himself for them when he died on the cross ([John 6:35; 6:51](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 4:8-31; 7:3; Numbers 14:11, 22; Deuteronomy 4:34; Psalms 74:9; 78:43; Matthew 12:38-39; John 2:1-11, 18, 23; 3:2; 4:48, 54; 6:2, 14, 26, 30; 7:31; 9:16; 10:41; 11:47; 12:18, 37; 15:24; 20:30; Acts 2:43; 4:16, 22, 30; 5:12; 8:6; 14:3; 15:12; Romans 15:19](#)

Misunderstanding in the Gospel of John

In John's Gospel, people often misunderstood Jesus (see [John 3:4; 4:11, 33; 7:35; 11:12-13](#)). They disagreed about who Jesus was. When they realized what he truly meant, some wanted to arrest him, while others wanted to follow him ([7:40-44](#)). Only later, after the disciples received the Holy Spirit, did they fully understand his importance (see [16:12-13](#)).

The world remains in spiritual darkness and struggles to understand life or God ([John 1:5, 10](#)). People cannot understand God's messages on their own unless God helps them understand. God's spiritual light enters the darkness, revealing the world's flaws. Many people retreat further into spiritual darkness because they prefer it over the light ([3:19-20](#)). Only God's Spirit can transform and help people see plainly as God's children do ([3:21; 8:12; 12:35-36, 46](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 6:8-13; 56:10-11; Matthew 13:11-17; John 1:10-11; 3:19-20; John 7:32-36; 9:40-41; 12:40; Romans 1:21; 2 Corinthians 3:13-18; 4:3-4; 1 John 2:9-11; Revelation 3:17](#)

Music in Ancient Israel

The earliest people who moved from place to place (called nomads) made music. The first musician

mentioned in the Bible is "Jubal," who played the harp and flute ([Genesis 4:21](#)).

Music was important from the beginning of Israel's worship in the tabernacle. In [Exodus 28:34-35](#), Aaron's robe had bells on the lower hem that sounded as he entered the holy place. Scripture records several songs created by God's people (for example, [Exodus 15:1-21; Deuteronomy 31:30-32:44; Judges 5:1-31](#)).

The first liturgical music in the Old Testament appears during the transfer of the ark of the covenant. King David and the Israelites sang, played instruments, and danced to honor the Lord ([2 Samuel 6:5](#)). David is famous for creating the musical instruments used in the temple ([2 Chronicles 7:6](#)). In the time after the exile (when the people of Israel returned from being captives in Babylon), the singers from the tribe of Levi were descendants of Asaph. Asaph was the chief musician appointed by David ([Ezra 2:41; Nehemiah 7:44; 11:22-23](#)). In simple terms, Israel's worship music and how it was organized began during the time of David.

The formal ceremonies in Solomon's Temple were different from the excited and spontaneous worship of David's time ([2 Chronicles 7:1-6](#)). Singers and musicians for temple worship were chosen from the tribe of Levi ([1 Chronicles 25:1, 7](#)). These musicians took turns participating in services held on weekdays, Sabbaths, and special holy days.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 4:21; Exodus 28:34-35; 2 Samuel 6:5; 2 Chronicles 7:6; Psalm 71:22-23](#)